

How It Works

We've perhaps jumped the gun a bit: how does one-on-one e-learning work? It's simple, really. At TutorVista, for just one example, the student chooses a plan—either \$19.99 per hour of coaching, or \$99.99 per month for unlimited tutoring. Then, an evaluation test determines the strong and weak areas of the student, and therefore, what precisely the learning sessions will attempt at achieving. In fact, TutorVista says their programmes are customised to ensure more time is spent targeting students' problem areas.

Students can then schedule sessions for any time they want; as the company says, "it's like having a tutor in their home or dorm 24x7." Any parent's dream.

During the session, student and teacher use headsets, and what is called a "whiteboard." This is an area of the screen where both can write on; whatever is written by one will be visible to the other, and vice-versa. Writing is accomplished via a graphics tablet. The student may also choose to use IM; communication thus happens via keyboard, mouse, tablet, microphone, and headphones. In addition, students have access to worksheets, lessons, practice tests, question banks, and animations. There's also a toll-free fax number so students can show tutors printouts of their work.

Coming to the Internet connection, one needs a high-speed line, and these are found at libraries and "civic centres" all over the US.

This Side Of The Book

We said earlier that tutors must be competent and well-trained. TutorVista ensures this. Experienced tutors with graduate degrees and the appropriate teaching credentials are considered, and are subsequently trained by TutorVista. There is an extensive online recruitment process that includes testing and interviews. A job offer is made only after would-be tutors complete training and the certification process. Recruiting and hiring a tutor "takes anywhere between three to five weeks," Ganesh says.

The company's tutors are located in India, the Philippines, and Hong Kong. That is how TutorVista manages to keep its prices so low. Ganesh makes no bones about it: "Prices are lower than (that of) the same service from the US or Europe since we leverage global resources from geographies wherein teaching resources are readily available and allow lower cost due to lower cost of living." Get them from where they come cheap, train them to world standards, and you have a winning formula.

Outsourcing as in call centres may have gotten a bad name in some areas: in a 2003 edition of *Dr. Dobb's Journal*, the editor-at-large cautioned the readership to call customer support (for software products) at hours when they would get "real, qualified engineers." He didn't go so far as to specifically say "American," but we got the idea.

It's very different here. Ganesh relates: "We did research with 25 parents and kids in the US before deciding to start this service and investing our first dollar on this project. The results were positive and gave us clues to what

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